(SADC) countries. In foreign policy it is more obsequious than the others to US foreign policy except on Palestine. India is pursuing ever closer relations with the US despite hiccups and is part of the US's China containment policies. Brazil is paying more attention to its intra-continental economic activities as well as showing more foreign policy independence from Washington. But outside Latin America this is more a way of asserting a greater self-confidence as an emerging power than actively seeking to put serious spokes in the functioning of US foreign policy. Russia and China, however, are both much more perturbed by US behaviour globally than the other three and thus seek greater political-economic cooperation.

In the BRICS grouping, South Africa and Brazil are among the most unequal societies in the world, while China's Gini coefficient has steadily risen, Russia's too, while India's Gini coefficient (calculated as it is on surveys of consumption expenditure and not on more reliable income data) is widely recognised to be a serious underestimate. In any case, rising inequalities of income and wealth have been characteristic of India's lopsided growth pattern over the last five decades, accelerating after the neoliberal reforms of 1991. It is hardly surprising that the number of dollar millionaires and billionaires is growing rapidly in the South. To make matters worse, Brazil, China and India are major land grabbers in Africa, and South Africa is itself involved in such activities. So much for BRICS 'leading the charge' against Northern exploitation of Africa. The BRICS' share in the continent's FDI stock and flows reached 14% and 25%, respectively, in 2010. This trend is likely to be reinforced in the future.

The members of BRICS, with the exception of Russia, have today a greater proportion of youth than in the advanced countries, but by 2050 it is projected that this gap will disappear, or in the case of South Africa and India be much reduced. But does this mean that between now and 2050 the fast-growing number of yearly new entrants into the national job market is going to prove an economic asset? Not necessarily; indeed, there are reasons to worry about the future performances. Per capita income levels of BRICS and some of the other 'emerging powers' like Indonesia are currently way behind those of the OECD countries. South Korea, Mexico and Turkey have entered the OECD club. In fact, it is simply not ecologically or materially possible (in terms of resource and energy use) for the per capita levels of even the BRICS and other 'high-flyers' to come anywhere close to average per capita levels of the most prosperous OECD countries as measured by actual international exchange rates, which give a truer picture of *global* purchasing power than PPP rates.

This means, given that the per capita figures are averages hiding gross